

What is the budget process?

The typical process:

- The School Administration presents a preliminary budget proposal at the 2nd School Committee meeting in January.
- A Q&A opportunity is on the agenda at the 1st School Committee meeting in February and March.
- The School Committee holds a budget hearing at the 2nd School Committee meeting in March, and the Committee votes on the budget at the conclusion of that hearing.
- The School Administration presents the School Committee approved budget to the Finance Committee in March.
- The School Committee budget is included in the Town's omnibus budget which is presented and voted at the Annual Town Meeting on the first Saturday in May.
- Residents can attend any of these meetings and make public comment.

Did you anticipate and plan for the COVID grants going away?

Yes. We did know those monies would be gone and we had been planning for cuts.

However, with those cuts, we will not be able to meet the same level of student need as we have been able to with the added staffing we have had for the last three years and we have been saying that for two and a half years publicly .

What we were not anticipating and planning for over the last two years was a double digit increase in health insurance. That is what makes the additional cuts (that we were not planning for over the last two years) necessary.

What was the plan for the ESSER funding?

The plan from the very beginning was that we would use the ESSER money while we had it to provide as much support as possible to close academic learning gaps and provide mental/behavioral health supports to those in need. We have seen the benefits for kids as a result of that plan. We will continue to do the best we can in those areas with reduced intervention staff (academic and behavioral health).

Why don't we just eliminate ESSER programs instead of staff?

We did not have ESSER programs. We used ESSER funds to hire counselors and academic intervention teaching staffing.

All but two positions have been recommended to be cut. We are recommending two social worker positions be kept, but we will cut two guidance counselors from the local budget in their place.

In the last three years, we added licensed counselors to address SEL/mental health. We have a School Committee adopted curriculum that we will continue to provide, just not as a stand alone class. Continuing to have an SEL curriculum is not impacting the budget.

It is difficult to put this into perspective without seeing the recommended budget spreadsheets. Are those available for review in order to provide relevant feedback?

The FY24 budget is posted on the district website. The FY25 budget spreadsheets are not finalized for public release as am I waiting for some decisions regarding proposed cuts in order to accurately reflect those in the budget spreadsheets.

The presentation mentions estimates for funding, is there data to show how that funding has fluctuated over time?

You can look back through the recommended budget presentations from prior years (March each year). Documents are available on the district website.

Do the funding estimates include income from field rentals etc.?

They do not. Funding estimates refers to the money coming from the state budget, state and federal grants, special education reimbursement.

Can the schools request a budget increase from the town or apply for grants?

We can ask for an increase and in the past we have. We already apply for and receive grants.

Is there help or assistance that could be applied for towards utilities?

The town participates in the Municipal Aggregation program with an expiring contract in November of 2024. However, we have been advised that we should see better rates at the end of the contract.

Has the district considered charging families for busing? It is a huge expense and many other towns have charged for transportation for years. Is this an option in Lunenburg?

Implementing bus fees is not something the administration is going to propose, however, the School Committee may wish to entertain that discussion.

Wasn't the district ~~was~~ getting funding from cell phone antennas on the field lights? Is that still a source of income, or did that never come to fruition?

The cell phone antenna generates revenue for the town.

The cuts to athletics are extremely concerning and don't appear to recognize the value of athletics to a student's social and emotional health.

We fully recognize the value of athletics and other extracurricular activities to students' social and emotional health. We saw the fallout firsthand following the spring season in 2020 when athletic programs were not allowed.

If athletics are cut from middle school where would our kids have the opportunity to play sports?

There are youth sports organizations in town and the surrounding area. We always post youth athletics flyers on our Community page on the district website.

Instead of eliminating Athletics completely can we have parent volunteers?

We do not plan to eliminate all athletics. If there is a reduction from a full-time Athletic Director to a part-time Athletic Director, they would not be able to oversee sports in all three seasons in grades 6-12. That is a big job. If there is a reduction, there would have to be a reduction in the programming, and we recommended elimination of middle school athletics if that is the case.

Eliminating the Athletic Director position will not be beneficial to students.

We do not disagree that eliminating the AD position would be detrimental. We are not advocating for elimination of the position, but it is a cut we included. In the presentation on January 17th, I explained the challenges that led to the creation of a full-time AD. I explained that we will return to that level of community dissatisfaction if we eliminate the position, or even reduce it to part-time. We suggested that the School Committee consider making the position part-time or making it an added role (for a stipend) for one of the LMHS assistant principals.

Athletic Trainers are required, so we cannot cut the trainer. Have you ever tried seeking volunteer medical professionals from the community to cover this need?

Athletic trainers are not required to be present for other sports other than football and hockey. Prior to hiring a full-time Trainer, we hired a trainer per diem to cover the football and hockey requirement (from MIAA). We have never solicited volunteer medical professionals to meet this requirement.

Can students get PE credit for playing sports to help reduce PE class sizes with a PE teacher cut?

The HS looked at the possibility of having sports count as PE credits and for a variety of reasons, the School Advisory Council recommended not to do that. I believe it has been considered and rejected twice in the last 8 years.

If Music and PE are being cut from THES what other specials will take their place?

Music and PE are not being cut at THES. We will be eliminating one of 2 physical education teachers (currently one at THES and one at Primary) The one remaining teacher will be shared between the two schools. We are reducing the amount of time the music teacher spends at THES. Chorus will be incorporated into the regular music class. Instrument lessons will still be available either before or after school (fee based).

**We should be keeping music classes not cutting them
We are not cutting art classes.
music classes.**

The recommended reduction to Music is based on lack of/limited student interest in these offerings. Our art classes always have robust enrollment; thus we are not suggesting cuts in art.

Is it necessary to be so heavily technologically based? Do we really need to do all our work on expensive Chromebooks?

We are not heavily technology based. We do have access to our curriculum materials online and we do have assessments that we administer online. Chromebooks are not very expensive, comparatively, and they are necessary. We must administer the MCAS test in grades 3-8, and high school on a device that meets the requirements to run the test. Since students will be tested on computers, they should use them routinely as part of their learning so they develop a comfort-level/mastery with them.

Do we need expensive curriculum like Amplify to succeed?

We do. Amplify is a vetted, evidence-based, rigorous, standards-aligned, on-grade-level curriculum. We have been advised that having such a curriculum is likely to become another unfunded mandate. The teachers piloted 3 different programs and unanimously selected Amplify for adoption. The School Committee voted to adopt the curriculum last year and we made the purchase of the curriculum with grant funding.

There is a curriculum in LMS called Amplify which is a considerable cost and does not seem to be loved by students nor teachers alike. Is this platform in a multi year contract or is it also on the table for cuts?

The Amplify curriculum was one of three programs piloted by the ELA teachers at the Middle School last year. They unanimously selected Amplify, which we recommended for adoption and the School Committee voted to adopt Amplify last spring. We purchased the curriculum with a grant. It is not on the table for cuts.

Many parents are not on board with the SEL programming and questioning costs associated.

There are no costs associated. That curriculum was already adopted by the SC and purchased in 2021.

Students are not prepared for the rigor of grade 6 because there is no homework at THES.

We are working with the teachers in Grade 6 to make appropriate adjustments to their practice to help 6th graders transition successfully. Hours of homework does not equate to rigor or good teaching.

Why are we eliminating languages at the middle school?

Languages are not being eliminated at the middle school. We said during the presentation that we looked at the impact of cutting one World Language teacher. The Department Head felt that would mean that we would not be able to offer World Language in grade 8. As we considered the longer term impact to that cut, we decided that cut was one that we would not recommend.

We have a good number of students interested in Latin and French. Most students take Spanish. Students do have the opportunity to take AP French, AP Latin, and AP Spanish. We have only one teacher certified to teach Latin, one certified to teach French. We have four certified to teach Spanish.

I am concerned that high school students will not have electives and the impact to performance in science.

In the last 3 years we added staff in History, Math, and ELA. We always had more teachers in Science than in other core content areas at LHS. We can reduce positions and still offer electives, just not as many. There are many classes at LHS with extremely low class sizes. It is a nice thing to be able to offer so much to our students, but we simply do not have enough resources to continue to fund the "nice to haves". In prioritizing achievement, we need to focus on meeting students' needs so they don't fall behind. While we had available funding, we were able to do both - meet needs and offer extra. We no longer have that option and must make difficult choices.

Our students in Middle School and High School outperform the state in Science/Technology. Two years ago we added a STEM "special" at Primary and THES. K-5 students take the added STEM class once in the 6-day specials rotation (art, music, library, gym, SEL, and STEM). We hold a K-5 STEM family night as well.

By cutting the Classroom Teacher position at THES and not moving that teacher to LMS with the large 5th grade class, class sizes will be very large.

We can eliminate that extra 5th grade teacher position at THES and not see an increase in class size in grades 3-8 as a result of the cut. We currently have enough teachers at the Middle School to support next year's class sizes. A teacher teaching grade 7 will be reassigned to grade 6 to support the larger incoming grade 6. There will still be enough teachers to have reasonable class sizes in grades 7 and 8.